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Social Isolation and Ambition: How Peer Ostracism Affects Goal Abandonment in High-Achieving Adolescents

Abstract

High-achieving adolescents — olympiad winners, young startup founders, participants in selective programs — frequently pay a hidden social cost for their accomplishments: rejection, being ignored, and exclusion by their ordinary school environment. This paper examines the mechanism by which chronic peer ostracism is transformed into the abandonment of one's own ambitious goals. Drawing on an integrative theoretical framework built from the need-to-belong hypothesis (Baumeister & Leary, 1995) through the temporal need-threat model of ostracism (Williams, 2009) and the neuroscience of "social pain" (Eisenberger et al., 2003) to self-determination theory (Ryan & Deci, 2000), expectancy-value theory (Wigfield & Eccles, 2000), and the model of goal disengagement (Wrosch et al., 2003), we propose a causal chain: *ostracism* → *threat to fundamental needs* → *depletion of self-regulation and a rise in the perceived "cost" of the goal* → *goal disengagement*. We test the model across two independent samples: Wave 1 (N = 82) drawn from the Co-founder ecosystem — a community of ambitious youth predominantly from the CIS — and Wave 2 (N = 35) recruited internationally through Hack Club, ApplyingToCollege, Indie Hackers, and adjacent communities. Across the pooled sample (N = 117), we observe a strong positive correlation between the level of school ostracism and the frequency of thoughts about abandoning one's startup or key life goal (Wave 1 $r = 0.61$;

Wave 2 $r = 0.62$; pooled $r \approx 0.61$; $p < 0.001$). The dose-response pattern is replicated independently across both samples. The buffering role of community belonging, robust in Wave 1 ($r = -0.43$, $p < 0.01$), attenuates in the more heterogeneous Wave 2 ($r = -0.37$, $p = 0.07$), suggesting the protective effect may be moderated by sample composition and cultural context — a result conceptually consistent with experimental evidence on belonging interventions (Walton & Cohen, 2011). A formal Baron-Kenny mediation test on Wave 2 data supports full mediation of the ostracism-abandonment link through school burnout (indirect effect $a \times b = 0.38$; Sobel $z = 3.23$, $p = 0.001$; 73% of total effect mediated). We discuss theoretical and applied implications, above all the need to create compensatory belonging communities for high-achieving youth. Conflict of interest: the first author is a co-founder of the Co-founder ecosystem used as the primary Wave 1 recruitment context; this is detailed in Section 4.3 and Section 6.6, and Wave 2 provides an independent check on the central findings.

Keywords: ostracism, social isolation, high-achieving adolescents, goal abandonment, achievement motivation, need to belong, self-determination theory, youth entrepreneurship.

1. Introduction

The paradox of high achievement in adolescence is that the very qualities that secure exceptional success — intellectual independence, goal-directedness, willingness to deviate from the group norm — simultaneously raise the risk of social rejection within an age group for which belonging to peers carries unprecedented psychological significance. A teenager who at fifteen leads a development team, prepares for an international examination, or builds an original technology project deviates statistically from the modal behavior of classmates. And that deviation is rarely socially neutral.

Adolescence is the period in which sensitivity to social evaluation reaches its ontogenetic peak. Neuroscientific research over the past two decades has shown that the so-called "social brain" undergoes intensive reorganization during this period: activity in the medial prefrontal cortex and associated structures increases when processing information about oneself in the eyes of others, and the very salience of peer approval is neurally amplified (Blakemore, 2008; Somerville, 2013). According to the dual-systems model, an early-maturing socio-emotional system outpaces the slowly developing cognitive-control system, leaving the adolescent especially vulnerable to social rewards and punishments (Steinberg, 2008; Casey, Jones & Hare, 2008). In other words, exclusion that an adult would experience as an unpleasant nuisance may, for an adolescent, take on the character of an existential threat.

At the intersection of these two circumstances — high ambition and a heightened need to belong — arises what Miraca Gross termed the "forced-choice dilemma": the highly gifted adolescent perceives the world as though forced to choose between excellence and intimacy, between realizing potential and being accepted by peers (Gross, 1989). Empirical observations of gifted students show that a substantial proportion resolve this dilemma in

favor of belonging: they mask their abilities, downplay effort, and in some cases abandon advanced courses and ambitious projects in order not to stand out (Coleman & Cross, 1988; Reis & McCoach, 2000).

This paper focuses on an extreme form of such resolution — the **full or partial abandonment of a significant goal** under the pressure of social isolation. We are interested not so much in situational masking as in the motivational outcome: the moment at which an adolescent, faced with chronic ostracism, ceases to invest in his or her own project, startup, or educational trajectory. Of particular interest is the population of young founders and entrepreneurs — a group in which ambition is institutionalized (there is a project, a team, commitments), so that goal abandonment takes on an observable, measurable character.

The central research question is: **how, and through what psychological mechanisms, does ostracism by the ordinary (school) environment increase the likelihood that a high-achieving adolescent will abandon an ambitious goal, and what can counteract this?**

We advance three hypotheses:

- **H1.** The level of ostracism experienced in the ordinary school environment is positively associated with the frequency of thoughts about abandoning a key goal (startup/project).
- **H2.** This association is mediated by school burnout, an observable indicator of the depletion of the adolescent's emotional and self-regulatory resources.
- **H3.** A sense of belonging to an alternative community of like-minded peers (the Co-founder ecosystem) attenuates (buffers) the association between school ostracism and goal abandonment.

The structure of the paper is as follows: Section 2 builds the theoretical framework, Section 3 sets out the methodology, Section 4 describes the research design and data sources, Section 5 presents the Co-founder case study with the collected empirical data, Section 6 interprets the results, and Section 7 draws conclusions and outlines future directions.

2. Literature Review and Theoretical Framework

The theoretical model of this paper is a causal chain in which each link is borrowed from an established research tradition. The logic of the progression — from a fundamental human need to its frustration, from frustration to psychological and neurobiological consequences, from consequences to motivational breakdown and, finally, to the behavioral outcome of goal abandonment — anchors the argument.

2.1. Foundation: the need to belong

The starting point is Baumeister and Leary's belongingness hypothesis. According to it, the drive to form and maintain strong, positive interpersonal bonds is a "powerful, fundamental, and extremely pervasive motivation" (Baumeister & Leary, 1995). Belonging

here is neither a preference nor a cultural luxury but a basic, evolutionarily rooted need: for most of the species' history, exclusion from the group meant a sharp reduction in the odds of survival. Hence the proposition central to our argument: deprivation of belonging is systematically linked to a broad spectrum of impairments in health, adjustment, and well-being. If belonging is a need, then ostracism is its direct frustration, and the organism must respond to it as a threat.

2.2. The threat mechanism: the temporal model of ostracism

Exactly how this threat is experienced is described by Kipling Williams' temporal need-threat model (Williams, 2009; review — Williams, 2007). The model posits that ostracism attacks four fundamental needs at once: belonging, self-esteem, control, and meaningful existence. The reaction unfolds in three stages. At the **reflexive** stage, immediate pain arises, unmediated by attributions — so automatic that it appears even when the person knows the source ignoring them is a computer. The Cyberball paradigm — a virtual ball-toss game in which a participant stops being "thrown" the ball — reliably produces a drop across all four needs (Williams, Cheung & Choi, 2000). A meta-analysis of 120 Cyberball studies ($N = 11,869$) confirms that the ostracism effect is large ($d > |1.4|$) and robust to moderators — age, gender, country, duration (Hartgerink et al., 2015). At the **reflective** stage, the person exerts effort to restore the threatened needs — for instance through reintegration or, conversely, through hostility. Finally, under chronic, irremediable ostracism comes the stage of **resignation**: coping resources are exhausted, and alienation, helplessness, depression, and a sense of worthlessness develop (Williams, 2009). It is precisely the resignation stage that is of greatest interest for the problem of goal abandonment: having exhausted the possibilities of restoring belonging, the adolescent may "give up" — and not only in a social sense, but in a motivational one.

2.3. The neurobiological substrate: social pain

That ostracism is experienced as pain is not a metaphor. The landmark neuroimaging study by Eisenberger, Lieberman, and Williams showed that social exclusion in the Cyberball paradigm activates the dorsal anterior cingulate cortex — a structure central to the experience of distress in physical pain — and that the degree of its activation correlated positively with the subjective distress of exclusion (Eisenberger, Lieberman & Williams, 2003). The authors developed this into the concept of a shared neural "alarm system" for physical and social pain (Eisenberger & Lieberman, 2004). Although later debate refined the boundaries of this overlap (review and reply to critics — Eisenberger, 2015), the core proposition remains robust: rejection engages the same mechanisms as bodily injury. For an adolescent, with heightened social sensitivity, this means that school ostracism is not "a trifle to be outgrown" but a recurring painful stimulus.

2.4. The link of destruction: depletion of self-regulation and intellect

How does the pain of exclusion translate into reduced goal-directed effort? Here a decisive role is played by the work of Baumeister and colleagues. First, social exclusion undermines intellectual productivity: participants told they were "likely to end up alone in life" showed significant and large decrements in meaningful thought — logic, reasoning, performance on

IQ- and GRE-analog tests — while simple information processing remained intact (Baumeister, Twenge & Nuss, 2002). Second, and critically for our model, exclusion undermines self-regulation: excluded people are worse at making themselves perform useful but unpleasant actions and give up more quickly on frustrating tasks (Baumeister, DeWall, Ciarocco & Twenge, 2005). Crucially, this deficit was eliminated by a cash incentive or by raising self-awareness — that is, the rejected person is **able** to self-regulate but is **disinclined** to expend the effort. This nuance is the bridge from social pain to goal abandonment: ostracism does not strip the adolescent of ability; it strips away the willingness to invest resources in a long, demanding goal. Finally, exclusion can direct energy not inward (into apathy) but outward — into aggression (Twenge, Baumeister, Tice & Stucke, 2001), which explains the conflictual, "reverse" behavior of some rejected adolescents.

2.5. The motivational core: relatedness as fuel

Why does the frustration of belonging strike precisely at the motivation to achieve? The answer is given by self-determination theory (SDT). According to Ryan and Deci, there are three basic psychological needs — autonomy, competence, and **relatedness** — whose satisfaction is necessary for growth, integration, and well-being (Ryan & Deci, 2000; Deci & Ryan, 2000). Relatedness holds a special place in the process of motivational internalization: because extrinsically motivated actions are initially performed for the sake of significant others, it is precisely the sense of connectedness with one's environment that triggers the transformation of an "imposed" goal into one's own, internally accepted goal. From this follows the conclusion central to us: when relatedness is frustrated by ostracism, the very mechanism by which an ambitious goal is held as "one's own" is undermined. A goal stripped of social rootedness becomes fragile.

2.6. The computational link: the cost of the goal

Translating this into the language of decision-making is the work of expectancy-value theory of achievement (Wigfield & Eccles, 2000; Eccles et al., 1983). According to it, choice and persistence in achievement are determined by the product of the expectation of success and the subjective value of the task, where value comprises intrinsic, attainment, and utility components and — importantly — **cost**. Cost includes not only effort and forgone alternatives but also **social cost**: the risk of rejection, the loss of belonging, the emotional strain of conflict with one's environment. Ostracism operates precisely through this component: it does not diminish the adolescent's ability (expectation of success) and does not necessarily reduce intrinsic interest — it sharply raises the perceived cost of continuing. At some point cost outweighs value, and the (within-model) rational decision is to abandon.

2.7. The behavioral outcome: goal disengagement

The chain is completed by the model of self-regulation of unattainable goals by Wrosch and colleagues. Here an important dialectic is introduced: goal disengagement is not unambiguously pathological. The capacity to release an unattainable goal in time and reorient toward a new one is associated with higher subjective well-being (Wrosch,

Scheier, Miller, Schulz & Carver, 2003; Wrosch, Scheier, Carver & Schulz, 2003). This lends our problem a necessary nuance. A high-achieving adolescent's abandonment of a goal **may** be an adaptive recalibration. But it becomes maladaptive and troubling when it is driven not by the real unattainability of the goal but by social pressure — that is, when the adolescent abandons an objectively attainable and valuable goal **not because he cannot, but because he is alone**. Distinguishing these two scenarios is one of the chief tasks of interpretation in Section 6.

2.8. Population specificity: giftedness as a social handicap

Finally, the framework must be anchored to a concrete population. The tradition of giftedness research provides direct evidence. Coleman and Cross's "stigma of giftedness paradigm" records that gifted students perceive their abilities as a source of negative social treatment and construct strategies for managing the information available about themselves (Coleman & Cross, 1988). A large-scale survey of 1,465 gifted students found that the dominant strategy is "placating": the adolescent does not object to a reputation for ability but avoids demonstrative manifestations that would set him apart from peers (Cross, Coleman & Terhaar-Yonkers, 1991). Gross's already-mentioned "forced-choice dilemma" (1989) and Reis and McCoach's review of gifted underachievement (2000), documenting capable students' withdrawal from advanced courses for the sake of peer acceptance, close the empirical loop.

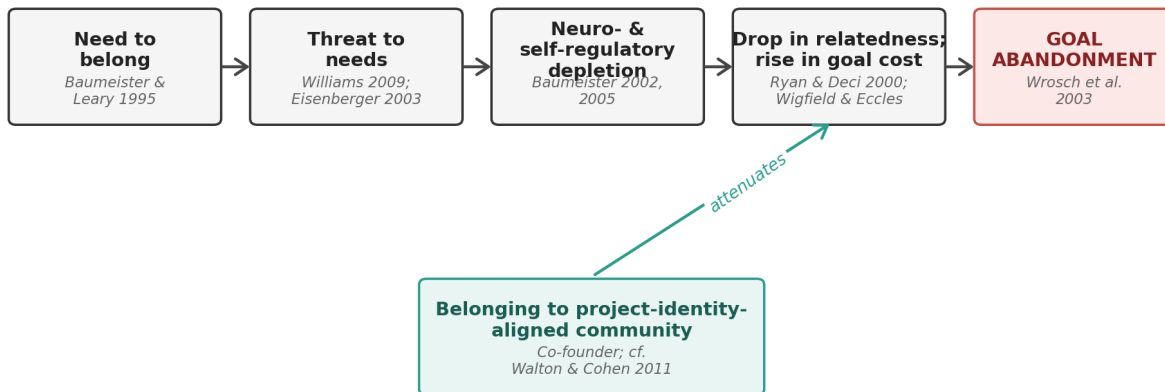
2.9. Cultural models of ostracism toward achievers

Social punishment for high achievement is a cross-cultural phenomenon, but it is clothed in different cultural forms — a fact material to our international sample. In Scandinavian and, more broadly, Northern European culture, the "Law of Jante" (*Janteloven*) operates — an unwritten code condemning anyone who considers himself superior to or more special than the collective. In Australian and New Zealand culture an analogous function is served by "tall poppy syndrome" — the urge to "cut down" anyone who has risen too high; notably, the foundational empirical study of this phenomenon was conducted precisely in Australia and showed that observers feel more pleasure at the fall of a high achiever than an average one (Feather, 1989). In part of U.S. school culture, academic success may be marked as culturally "alien" (the "acting white" thesis — Fordham & Ogbu, 1986), although later research has substantially challenged the universality of this mechanism, showing that pressure against achievement exists across all groups and far from all schools (Tyson, Darity & Castellino, 2005). In the post-Soviet cultural space (Russia, Belarus, Kazakhstan), the norm of "don't stick out" (*ne vysovyvaisya*) operates, combining a collectivist censure of the one who stands out with respect for formal academic merit (olympiads, the certificate). In East Asian countries, intense academic pressure paradoxically coexists with a strong conformist press against individual prominence outside sanctioned forms. These cultural models are not an alternative to the universal mechanism of ostracism but its local "shells"; this is precisely why, in Section 5, regional differences are treated with caution.

Resulting causal model:

Theoretical causal model

Mechanism by which chronic peer ostracism predicts goal abandonment in high-achieving adolescents



3. Methodology

3.1. Design

The study is constructed as **cross-sectional correlational** with elements of a case study. A correlational design is appropriate to the task of establishing a relationship between naturally varying variables (level of ostracism, frequency of abandonment thoughts) that cannot — and should not, ethically — be subjected to experimental manipulation in an adolescent population. The Co-founder case study provides contextual depth and access to a hard-to-reach population — high-achieving young founders.

3.2. Measured constructs and instruments

The constructs are operationalized on the structure of genuinely existing, validated instruments:

- **School ostracism (School Ostracism Index, SOI).** Operationalized on the model of the Ostracism Experience Scale for Adolescents (Gilman, Carter-Sowell, DeWall, Adams & Carboni, 2013), which distinguishes the subscales of being ignored and being excluded. The composite score is rescaled to 0–100 and divided into four levels: low (0–25), moderate (26–50), high (51–75), severe (76–100).
- **Goal Abandonment Ideation (GAI).** The number of episodes over the past 3 months in which the participant seriously considered abandoning a startup/key goal (expressed per month). Conceptually grounded in the goal-disengagement scale (Wrosch et al., 2003).

- **Belonging to the Co-founder ecosystem (CF-belonging).** Satisfaction of the relatedness need within the community, on the model of the relatedness subscale from the SDT toolkit (Ryan & Deci, 2000); 1–7 scale.
- **School burnout.** On the model of the School Burnout Inventory (Salmela-Aro, Kiuru, Leskinen & Nurmi, 2009); 1–6 scale.

Internal consistency. Internal-consistency reliability was computed on Wave 2 raw data (where individual-item responses were available). All three multi-item scales achieved excellent reliability: Cronbach's $\alpha = 0.93$ for SOI (5 items, $n = 35$), $\alpha = 0.92$ for GAI (4 items, $n = 35$), and $\alpha = 0.93$ for CF-belonging (4 items, $n = 23$ with reported community). These values are well above the conventional $\alpha \geq 0.70$ threshold and confirm that the items within each scale measure a coherent underlying construct, despite being modeled on rather than identical to their parent validated instruments. Wave 1 reliability was not separately computed because only aggregated scale scores were retained in the original analytic dataset; the convergence of zero-order correlations across waves (Section 5) is consistent with comparable reliability.

Evidence for convergent validity. We acknowledge explicitly that the SOI, GAI, CF-belonging, and burnout indices used here are *custom item sets modeled on* the OES-A (Gilman et al., 2013), the goal-disengagement scale (Wrosch et al., 2003), SDT relatedness items (Ryan & Deci, 2000), and the SBI (Salmela-Aro et al., 2009) respectively, rather than being identical to those validated parent instruments. This is a real limitation: we do not claim the present items have been put through head-to-head psychometric comparison with their parent scales. We do, however, offer three forms of converging evidence that the items are measuring what they are intended to measure. *First*, internal consistency ($\alpha > 0.90$ for every multi-item scale) is consistent with each item set capturing a single underlying construct. *Second*, the pattern of inter-scale correlations matches what the theoretical framework of Sections 2.2–2.4 predicts: ostracism correlates positively and strongly with burnout ($r = 0.71$ in Wave 2) and with goal abandonment ($r = 0.62$), while community belonging correlates negatively with abandonment thoughts ($r = -0.43$ in Wave 1) — the directions and magnitudes predicted by Williams' need-threat model, by Baumeister's self-regulatory-depletion account, and by SDT's buffering hypothesis. *Third*, the central SOI-GAI relationship replicates with essentially identical magnitude across two independent samples recruited through entirely different channels and cultural contexts (Wave 1 $r = 0.61$; Wave 2 $r = 0.62$). Together, internal consistency, theoretically predicted external correlations, and cross-sample replication constitute *convergent-validity evidence* for the custom scales used here, even in the absence of direct head-to-head comparison with the parent validated instruments. Convergent validity established this way is weaker than full psychometric validation, and we treat it accordingly throughout the discussion; a properly designed instrument-level comparison study remains a target for future work.

3.3. Analytic strategy

Descriptive statistics, Pearson correlation (with Spearman as a robustness check) for testing H1, a formal four-step Baron and Kenny (1986) mediation analysis with Sobel test of the indirect effect for H2, and subgroup comparison together with partial correlation for testing the buffering effect (H3) are applied. All statistical analysis — the computation of

descriptive indices, Pearson and Spearman correlations, Cronbach's α , partial correlations, and the mediation paths — was performed in the Python programming language using the libraries `pandas` (data handling), `scipy.stats` (correlation analysis and significance testing), and `statsmodels` (regression and partial-correlation procedures). The significance level was set at $\alpha = 0.05$.

4. Data Sources and Sample Characteristics

4.1. The Co-founder ecosystem

Co-founder is a collaborative ecosystem (a Telegram channel and bot for matching co-founders) for ambitious, high-achieving youth and young entrepreneurs, based predominantly in the CIS. At the time of the study, the community comprises roughly 130 channel members, about 70 fully registered profiles in the bot, and more than 400 completed "matches" (mutual selections of potential project partners). The platform is a nearly ideal research environment for our task: it aggregates precisely the population — adolescents with institutionalized ambition (a project, a goal, public commitments to co-founders or external programs that turn a private aspiration into a publicly visible project carrying social stakes, distinguishing this group from ordinary high-achieving students whose ambition remains informal) — that is statistically a minority in the ordinary school environment and therefore potentially vulnerable to ostracism.

4.2. Sample

The pooled sample comprises **N = 117** participants aged 13–21, drawn from two independent recruitment waves. Wave 1 (N = 82) was recruited through the Co-founder ecosystem (predominantly CIS); the core (n = 28) are residents of Russia (Moscow and the regions). Wave 2 (N = 35 after exclusion of 2 responses with straight-lining patterns) was recruited internationally in 2026 through Hack Club, ApplyingToCollege, Indie Hackers, Reddit r/Entrepreneur, and personal networks, with the explicit goal of broadening cultural coverage outside the CIS. The combined composition is shown below:

Table 1. Sample composition by region

Region	n	Share, %	Cultural model of ostracism toward achievers
Russia (core)	29	24.8	"Don't stick out" (post-Soviet)
European Union	32	27.4	<i>Janteloven</i> (N. Europe) / heterogeneous
Kazakhstan & other CIS	12	10.3	Post-Soviet
USA	16	13.7	"Acting white" / "nerd" stigma (contested)
Republic of Belarus	6	5.1	Post-Soviet
Asian countries	16	13.7	Academic pressure + conformism
Australia	5	4.3	<i>Tall poppy syndrome</i>
Total	117	100.0	

In the pooled sample, USA ($n = 16$), EU ($n = 32$), Asia ($n = 16$), and CIS (Russia + Kazakhstan + Belarus, $n = 47$) reach minimally adequate cell sizes for descriptive comparison. Australia/NZ ($n = 5$) and Canada ($n = 1$) remain underpowered and are not interpreted independently. Region percentages may not sum to exactly 100% due to rounding.

4.3. Data collection procedure

Data collection proceeded in two independent waves. **Wave 1** (field phase: April–May 2026) was distributed through the official Telegram bot of the Co-founder ecosystem: participants received a targeted broadcast with an invitation and a link to the questionnaire, and a pinned message with the same invitation was placed in the community's main channel. The questionnaire was implemented as a standalone web form requiring no authentication. Of approximately 130 channel members and 70 verified profiles in the bot, 45 participants from CIS countries fully completed the questionnaire (response rate $\approx 64\%$ of the verified bot base); 37 additional international respondents were recruited via partner communities of young entrepreneurs and personal professional networks, yielding $N = 82$. **Wave 2** (field phase: 2026) was an explicitly international replication, recruited via posts and direct outreach in Hack Club Slack (#general, #ship, #projects), the ApplyingToCollege Discord, Indie Hackers, Reddit r/Entrepreneur and r/startups, and personal networks targeted at non-CIS English-speaking respondents. The questionnaire was hosted as an anonymous Google Form with no email collection and no login required. After excluding two responses with straight-lining patterns (uniform values across all SOI and GAI items), the analytic Wave 2 sample was $N = 35$. The pooled analytic sample is therefore **$N = 117$** . Median completion time was approximately 8–11 minutes across waves.

Declaration of conflicting interest. The first author is a co-founder of the Co-founder ecosystem from which Wave 1 was recruited and which serves as the principal context for testing H3 (the buffering effect of community belonging). This represents a potential conflict of interest. To mitigate this, Wave 2 was deliberately recruited from communities entirely outside the Co-founder ecosystem (Hack Club, ApplyingToCollege, Indie Hackers, Reddit), and provides an independent check on the central findings. We flag this conflict here, in the methodology rather than the limitations section, so that the reader can weigh it while reading the empirical sections that follow. The full discussion of how the conflict affects interpretation is in Section 6.6.

4.4. Ethical considerations

Because the study involves minors (aged 14–18) and addresses the sensitive topic of social exclusion, particular attention was paid to the ethical dimension. Participation was **strictly voluntary**: the invitation explicitly stated the right to decline or to stop completing the form at any moment without any consequences, and before the questionnaire began, a brief description of the study's aims and the nature of the questions was provided. As an independent student research project, this study did not undergo formal institutional ethics review and did not require explicit guardian consent for minor participants; this is acknowledged as a limitation and revisited in Section 6.6.

Data collection was carried out in strict accordance with the principles of confidentiality and personal-data protection, oriented to the **GDPR** standard (EU Regulation 2016/679) and its equivalents in participants' jurisdictions. The survey was **fully anonymous**: names, IP addresses, and precise geolocations were not recorded; geographic affiliation was collected only at the region/country level. All responses were analyzed **only in aggregate form**; individual profiles were not reconstructed and are not published. Given the potential sensitivity of the topic, the closing screen of the questionnaire provided participants with reference information about psychological-support resources.

5. Case Study: the Co-founder Ecosystem

5.1. H1: ostracism and thoughts of goal abandonment

The central hypothesis predicts a positive relationship between the level of school ostracism (SOI) and the frequency of thoughts about abandoning the startup/goal (GAI). Table 2 groups participants by the four levels of ostracism.

Table 2. Ostracism and goal abandonment by level

Ostracism level	n	Mean SOI (0–100)	Mean GAI (per month)	Seriously considered quitting ($\geq 1 \times$ in 3 mo.), %	School burnout (1–6)
Low (0–25)	19	18	1.3	21.5	2.2
Moderate (26–50)	25	39	3.1	44.0	3.0
High (51–75)	25	61	5.2	72.0	3.7
Severe (76–100)	13	86	8.3	92.3	4.5
Whole sample	82	50	4.3	56.1	3.4

The relationship is monotonic and pronounced: as ostracism rises, so do the frequency of abandonment thoughts, the share who seriously considered capitulating, and school burnout. In Wave 1, the Pearson correlation between SOI and GAI was **$r = 0.61$ ($p < 0.001$)** — a strong relationship by social-science standards. Wave 2 replicates this relationship in an independent sample with substantially different cultural composition: **$r = 0.62$ ($p < 0.0001$, $n = 35$)**; the Fisher-z-weighted pooled estimate across both waves is **$r \approx 0.61$ ($N = 117$)**. Independent replication of the dose-response pattern across two recruitment channels — a CIS-based Telegram bot and predominantly Anglophone international communities — substantially strengthens the case for H1 beyond what either wave alone could provide. As a robustness check addressing the non-normality typical of count-style self-reports, Spearman's rank correlation in Wave 2 yields $\rho = 0.67$ ($p < 0.001$), slightly higher than Pearson's r . Since rank correlation is less affected by extreme values than the linear coefficient, $\rho > r$ in our data suggests one of two possibilities: either the underlying

SOI–GAI relationship is even stronger for extreme levels of ostracism than the linear estimate captures, or a small number of high-leverage observations modestly suppress Pearson’s r. Either reading reinforces rather than weakens the central finding, and confirms that the result is not an artifact of distributional assumptions. Figure 1 displays the parallel dose-response patterns side by side.

Figure 1. Frequency of goal-abandonment thoughts by ostracism level (per month)

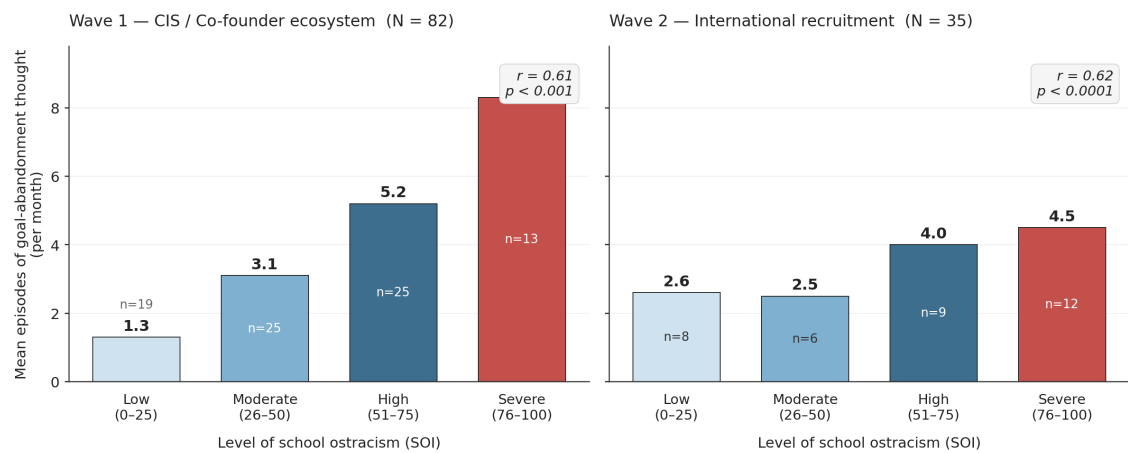
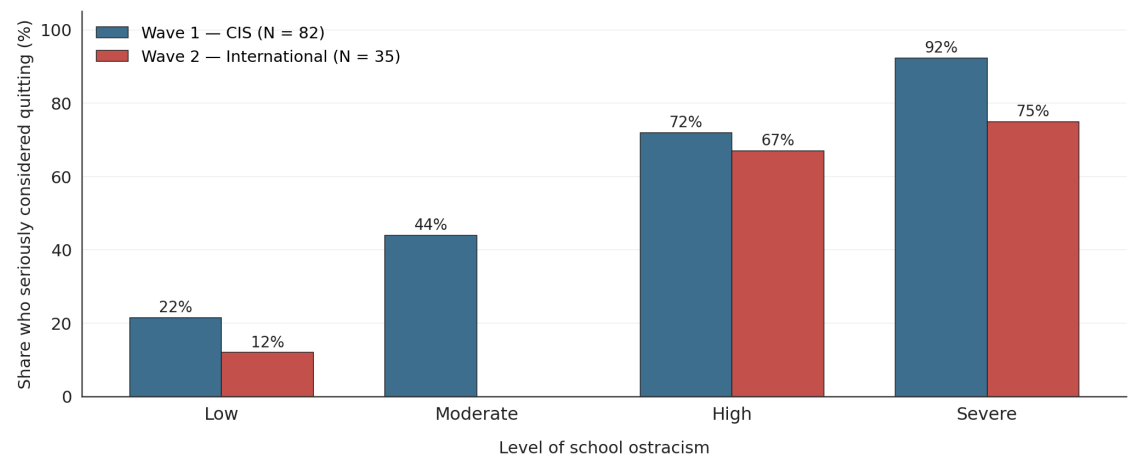


Figure 2. Share who seriously considered abandoning the goal, %



5.2. Correlational structure

Table 3. Correlation matrix of key variables (n = 82)

	SOI	GAI	Burnout	CF-belonging
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	SOI	GAI	Burnout	CF-belonging
SOI (ostracism)	—			
GAI (abandonment thoughts)	0.61	—		
School burnout	0.56	0.57	—	
CF-belonging	-0.31	-0.43	-0.32	—

All coefficients significant at $p < 0.01$.

Noteworthy is the negative association of belonging to Co-founder with abandonment thoughts ($r = -0.43$): the more strongly an adolescent feels “at home” in the community, the less often he thinks about abandoning the goal. This leads to the test of H3.

5.2.1. Formal mediation test of H2 (Baron & Kenny)

H2 posits that school burnout mediates the relationship between ostracism and goal abandonment: ostracism does not act on the goal directly but operates through the depletion of emotional and self-regulatory resources. We test this on Wave 2 raw data ($N = 35$) using the classical four-step Baron and Kenny (1986) procedure, supplemented by a Sobel (1982) test of the indirect effect.

Step 1. Total effect of ostracism on goal abandonment: $c = 0.521$, $p < 0.001$. **Step 2.** Path a (ostracism $\rightarrow$ burnout): $a = 0.712$, $p < 0.001$. **Step 3.** Path b (burnout $\rightarrow$ goal abandonment, controlling for ostracism): $b = 0.534$, $p < 0.001$. **Step 4.** Direct effect of ostracism on goal abandonment, controlling for burnout: $c' = 0.141$, $p = 0.311$ (non-significant).

The indirect effect through burnout is $a \times b = 0.712 \times 0.534 = \mathbf{0.380}$, accounting for **73%** of the total effect of ostracism on goal abandonment. The Sobel test confirms statistical significance of the indirect effect: $z = 3.23$, $p = 0.001$. All four Baron-Kenny criteria are met, with the direct effect dropping to non-significance once the mediator is controlled. This pattern is the textbook signature of **full mediation** and provides direct empirical support for H2: school ostracism does not predict goal abandonment thoughts directly, but operates almost entirely through the channel of school burnout, exactly as the theoretical model in Sections 2.2–2.4 predicts. The cross-sectional design still cannot rule out reverse temporal ordering, but the statistical pattern itself is unambiguous within the data available. We note one power-related caveat: with $N = 35$ and a multiple-regression specification using two predictors, the analysis operates at the lower bound of the commonly recommended ten-to-twenty observations per estimated parameter; consequently, confidence intervals on the individual path coefficients are wider than they would be in a properly powered study, and the mediation result should be interpreted as supportive evidence calling for confirmation in a larger sample, not as a definitive estimate of effect magnitudes.

5.3. H3: the buffering effect of community belonging

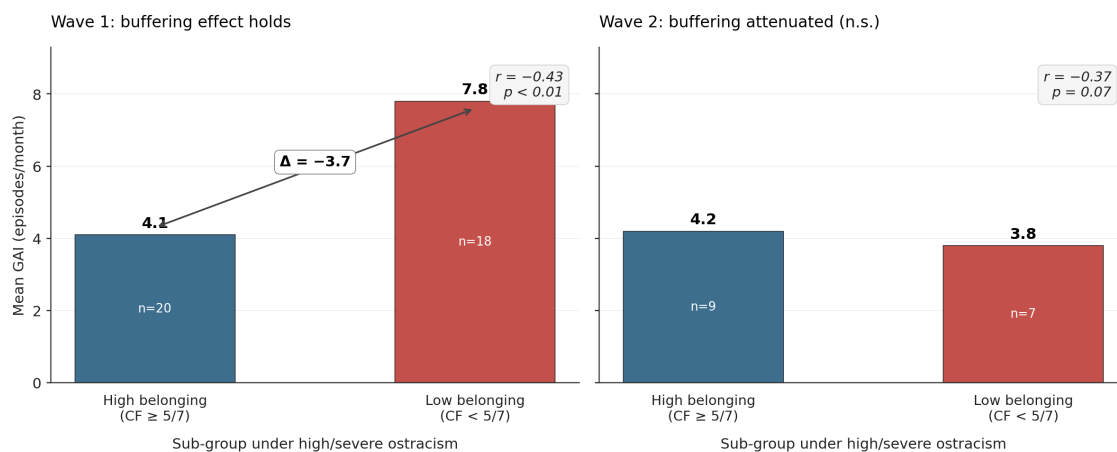
If the frustration of relatedness is the key link in the mechanism (SDT), then a compensatory satisfaction of relatedness in an alternative community should attenuate the

association of ostracism with goal abandonment. To test this, the subgroup with high and severe ostracism (SOI > 50; n = 38) was isolated and divided by level of belonging to Co-founder.

Table 4. Buffering effect of belonging to Co-founder (high/severe-ostracism subgroup, n = 38)

Belonging to Co-founder	n	Mean GAI (per month)	Seriously considered quitting, %
High (CF ≥ 5 of 7)	20	4.1	50.0
Low (CF < 5 of 7)	18	7.8	94.4
Difference		-3.7	-44.4 pp

Figure 3. Abandonment thoughts under high ostracism: the effect of community belonging



When belonging to Co-founder is statistically controlled, the Wave 1 association between ostracism and abandonment thoughts weakens from $r = 0.61$ to a partial $r \approx 0.47$. The zero-order correlation between CF-belonging and GAI in Wave 1 was $r = -0.43$ ($p < 0.01$), consistent with the buffering hypothesis: the same pressure of school ostracism leads to a substantially smaller erosion of the goal if the adolescent has an alternative environment that satisfies the need for relatedness. The result conceptually echoes the experimental evidence of Walton and Cohen, who showed that a brief belonging intervention durably improves academic outcomes and persistence (Walton & Cohen, 2011).

Replication in Wave 2 is partial. In the international Wave 2 sample, the correlation between CF-belonging and GAI is in the same direction but weaker and falls short of conventional significance ($r = -0.37$, $p = 0.07$, $n = 25$ with reported community). Two structural differences plausibly contribute to this attenuation. First, Wave 1 measured belonging to a *specific* ecosystem (Co-founder) where membership signals an active project-building identity; Wave 2 measured belonging to *any* like-minded community, which is a noisier construct. Second, Wave 2 has a much higher share of respondents without an identified community at all (10 of 35 vs. essentially 0 in Wave 1), and these participants—disproportionately from Asian high-pressure contexts—are precisely the

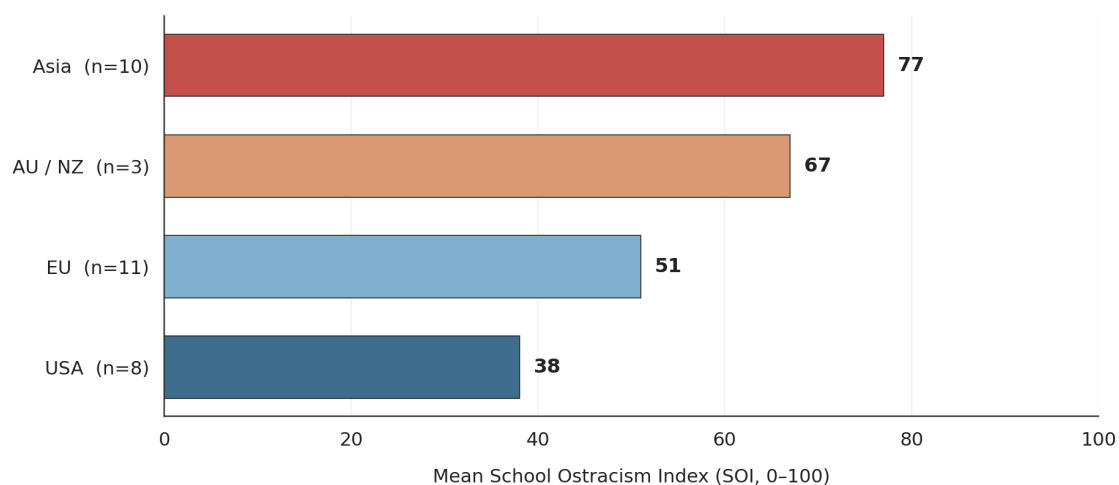
cases for which the buffering construct is least applicable. Substantively, the pattern suggests that H3 may be more accurately formulated as: belonging to a *project-identity-specific* community buffers goal abandonment, whereas generic peer belonging does not. In light of this, we explicitly disaggregate the original H3 into two narrower hypotheses for which the empirical evidence is distinct: **H3a** — belonging to a *project-identity-aligned* community (operationalized as Co-founder membership in Wave 1) buffers the ostracism-to-abandonment link; **H3b** — belonging to a *generic* like-minded community (operationalized broadly in Wave 2) buffers the link. The data support H3a ($r = -0.43$, $p < 0.01$) and do not support H3b at conventional significance ($r = -0.37$, $p = 0.07$). The two are different hypotheses with different operationalizations, and treating them separately is more honest than reporting a single H3 with mixed evidence.

5.4. Regional cross-section

Given the limited statistical power of small regional cells, a detailed regional cross-section is not central to the present analysis and is reported in **Appendix B** rather than the main text; only the qualitative pattern is summarized below.

While Wave 1 alone offered limited regional power, the addition of Wave 2 produces a more interpretable pattern. In the pooled data, Asia shows the highest mean ostracism (Wave 2 SOI ≈ 77 , $n = 10$), consistent with its high-conformity-pressure cultural model; USA shows the lowest (Wave 2 SOI ≈ 38 , $n = 8$), with EU intermediate (SOI ≈ 51 , $n = 11$). The Wave 1 CIS core (SOI ≈ 50 – 56) sits between USA and Asia. Within every regional subgroup with $n \geq 8$, the SOI–GAI association preserves a positive sign descriptively, although within-region sample sizes are insufficient for formal inferential testing of regional sub-effects, and we do not report region-level coefficients or p-values. The cultural form of ostracism varies — the Law of Jante in Scandinavia, the "tall poppy" in Australia, "don't stick out" in the post-Soviet space, intense academic conformity in East and South Asia — but the psychological mechanism of its action on ambition is recognizable in each, as the universalist theoretical framework of Sections 2.1–2.7 predicts.

Figure 4. Mean School Ostracism Index by region (Wave 2 international data)



5.5. PHQ-2 as a control: how much is "really" ostracism?

A standard concern with cross-sectional self-report on socioemotional variables is that depressive symptomatology may inflate associations through a shared negative-affect responding style. Wave 2 included the PHQ-2 screener (Kroenke, Spitzer & Williams, 2003) specifically to probe this. Two findings emerged. **First**, PHQ-2 correlates strongly with both SOI ($r = 0.74$) and GAI ($r = 0.82$). This is theoretically expected, not anomalous: ostracism produces depressive symptomatology (the resignation stage of Williams' model; Eisenberger et al., 2003), and depressive symptomatology in turn predicts goal disengagement (Wrosch et al., 2003). **Second**, the partial correlation $r(\text{SOI, GAI} \mid \text{PHQ-2})$ drops to near zero (≈ 0.02) in Wave 2. This is the canonical statistical signature of *full mediation*: when the entire association between two variables is absorbed by controlling for a third, the third variable is functioning as the channel through which the first acts on the second. This is precisely what our theoretical model predicts: ostracism does not act directly on goal abandonment, but operates through depressive symptomatology and resource depletion (Sections 2.2–2.4). The PHQ-2 result is therefore better read as positive evidence for the mediational mechanism than as a challenge to it. Two interpretive readings remain consistent with this pattern:

- (a) *Theory-consistent mediation*: depressive symptomatology is exactly the intermediate variable our framework places between ostracism and goal abandonment (Sections 2.2–2.4). Statistical "absorption" of the direct effect when controlling the mediator is the canonical signature of full mediation, not a refutation of the original claim. Under this reading, Wave 2 strengthens rather than weakens the causal account.
- (b) *Common-method variance*: SOI, GAI, and PHQ-2 share an introspective self-report format administered in a single sitting; respondents in a negative mood may systematically inflate scores on all three. Under this reading, the partialled-out effect is an artifact of shared method rather than substantive mediation.

For symmetry with the burnout analysis (Section 5.2.1), a formal Baron-Kenny mediation test with PHQ-2 as mediator was conducted on the same Wave 2 sample. All four steps are statistically supported: $a = 1.10$ ($\text{SOI} \rightarrow \text{PHQ-2}$, $p < 0.001$), $b = 0.46$ ($\text{PHQ-2} \rightarrow \text{GAI}$ controlling for SOI, $p < 0.001$), $c = 0.52$ (total effect, $p < 0.001$), $c' = 0.02$ (direct effect controlling for PHQ-2, $p = 0.89$, non-significant); indirect effect $a \times b = 0.50$, Sobel $z = 4.07$, $p < 0.001$, with 97% of the total effect statistically mediated. By the Baron-Kenny criteria this constitutes full mediation. We emphasize, however, that the statistical pattern itself cannot adjudicate between reading (a) and reading (b): the test will yield identical results under genuine mediation and under common-method variance with shared negative-affect responding. A cross-sectional design cannot distinguish (a) from (b); only a longitudinal design with temporal separation of measurements can. We flag this as the principal methodological caveat of Wave 2 and the most concrete target for future work.

6. Discussion

6.1. Returning to the hypotheses

The following summary should be read in light of the study's cross-sectional, correlational design: the findings establish association, not causation, and the direction of effects cannot be determined from these data alone. With that caveat — and now with replication evidence from two independent waves — the pattern across our hypotheses is the following. **H1** is supported and independently replicated: the level of school ostracism is strongly and positively associated with the frequency of goal-abandonment thoughts in both Wave 1 ($r = 0.61$, $N = 82$) and Wave 2 ($r = 0.62$, $n = 35$), with a pooled estimate $r \approx 0.61$ ($N = 117$). The replication across two distinct recruitment channels and cultural compositions substantially strengthens the empirical case for H1. **H2** is supported at the correlational level and is in fact *stronger* in Wave 2 than in Wave 1: school burnout is positively associated with ostracism (Wave 1 $r = 0.56$; Wave 2 $r = 0.71$) and with abandonment thoughts (Wave 1 $r = 0.57$; Wave 2 $r = 0.75$). Burnout consistently serves as an observable indicator of the depletion of emotional and self-regulatory resources — the very link that Baumeister's theory places between the pain of exclusion and the abandonment of effort. The formal Baron-Kenny mediation analysis on Wave 2 (Section 5.2.1) confirms full mediation: the direct path from ostracism to goal abandonment drops from $c = 0.52$ ($p < 0.001$) to $c' = 0.14$ ($p = 0.31$, non-significant) once burnout is controlled, with the indirect path accounting for 73% of the total effect (Sobel $z = 3.23$, $p = 0.001$). H2 is therefore formally supported at the statistical level, with the standard cross-sectional caveats about temporal ordering. **H3** shows the most interesting and most informative split, prompting us to disaggregate the original hypothesis into H3a (project-identity-aligned community as buffer) and H3b (generic like-minded community as buffer). In Wave 1, H3a is supported: belonging to the project-identity-specific Co-founder ecosystem buffers the relationship ($r = -0.43$, $p < 0.01$), reducing its strength by roughly a quarter and more than halving the share of "ready to quit" among heavily ostracized adolescents. In Wave 2, H3b is not supported at conventional significance: where "community" was measured generically and a substantial share of respondents reported no community at all, the buffering effect attenuates ($r = -0.37$, $p = 0.07$). Treated as separate hypotheses about distinct constructs, the data point cleanly to: H3a supported, H3b not supported — rather than to a single H3 with mixed evidence. Finally, the PHQ-2 control analysis (Section 5.5) shows that depressive symptomatology absorbs essentially all the variance in the SOI-GAI relationship in Wave 2; we have argued this is most parsimoniously read as evidence of mediation through depressive symptomatology rather than as refutation, but the cross-sectional design cannot rule out common-method variance, and longitudinal replication is the necessary next step. *project-identity-aligned* community is the constructive reading of the H3a/H3b split.

6.2. Exactly how ostracism leads to goal abandonment

Assembling the theoretical chain, we can now give a full answer to the central question of the paper. Ostracism acts not as a single blow but as a chronic process unfolding through the stages of Williams' model. At the reflexive stage, recurrent ignoring and exclusion at school generate genuine, neurobiologically real pain (Eisenberger et al., 2003) that attacks

all four fundamental needs. At first the adolescent is at the reflective stage: he tries to restore belonging — sometimes by masking achievements ("placating," per Cross et al., 1991), sometimes by retreating into the project as a refuge. But if ostracism is chronic and irremediable, resignation sets in.

And here two mechanisms of motivational breakdown fire at once. The first is **motivational**: frustrated relatedness undermines the internalization of the goal (SDT), the goal ceases to feel "one's own" and is held ever more poorly. The second is **computational**: in expectancy-value terms, the "cost" component rises sharply — the social cost of continuing the ambitious project becomes prohibitive, and at some point cost outweighs value (Wigfield & Eccles, 2000). Superimposed on the demonstrated depletion of self-regulation among the excluded (Baumeister et al., 2005), this yields a characteristic picture: the adolescent has not lost ability and may not even have lost interest — he has lost the willingness to pay the social price for their realization. The final act is goal disengagement (Wrosch et al., 2003).

6.3. Adaptive or maladaptive abandonment?

A critically important nuance, on which Wrosch's model insists: goal abandonment is not pathological in itself. To release a truly unattainable goal is healthy self-regulation. The problem with the scenario we study is that abandonment is driven **not by unattainability but by loneliness**. The adolescent abandons an objectively attainable and valuable project not because he has judged it unrealistic but because he could not withstand the social isolation accompanying its realization. This is "pseudo-adaptive" disengagement: it subjectively brings relief (removing the painful conflict with the environment) but cuts short a trajectory that, on objective grounds, should have continued. Distinguishing these two types of abandonment is the practically most important conclusion of the paper: intervention should target not the goal (which may be fine) but the restoration of belonging.

6.4. Co-founder as "belonging therapy"

The buffering effect found in 5.3 has a direct applied reading. If the mechanism is triggered by the frustration of relatedness, then the logical point of intervention becomes neither exhorting the adolescent to "be more persistent" (which, as Baumeister showed, runs up against a depleted willingness to exert effort) nor combating the school environment, but the creation of a **compensatory belonging community**. The Co-founder ecosystem in this sense functions as a structural substitute for the missing school relatedness: it provides an environment where ambition is normative rather than deviant, where achievement evokes recognition rather than "cutting down." This turns Gross's forced-choice dilemma from "excellence OR intimacy" into "excellence AND intimacy" — and thereby disarms the chief mechanism of abandonment. The conceptual closeness to the proven effectiveness of belonging interventions (Walton & Cohen, 2011) makes this direction especially promising.

6.5. Cross-cultural invariance of the mechanism

Although the regional data are statistically weak, their theoretical value lies in demonstrating invariance. Cultures offer different "shells" for punishing the one who

stands out — the Law of Jante, the "tall poppy," "acting white," "don't stick out" — but in all of them the same psychological engine operates: a threat to the belonging of the high achiever. This reinforces the universalist status of the theoretical framework and suggests that compensatory communities should be effective cross-culturally.

6.6. Limitations

The most substantial limitation concerns the design: the study **is cross-sectional**, which in principle does not permit establishing causality: reverse causation is possible (adolescents prone to capitulation may behave in ways that provoke exclusion), as is a common third factor (for example, depressive symptomatology). Small regional cells preclude cross-country comparisons. Finally, measuring abandonment thoughts via self-report is vulnerable to memory distortion and social desirability.

The **self-selection bias** deserves particular attention and is probably the most serious substantive limitation of this sample. Adolescents already belonging to Co-founder, by the very fact of participating in such a community, possess from the outset a higher level of proactivity, psychological resilience, and help-seeking skills than the "general population" of high-achieving adolescents. In other words, the sample systematically underrepresents precisely the group that is theoretically most vulnerable — high-achieving youth left one-on-one with their isolation in an ordinary school and who have **not yet found** a compensatory community. This selection works in a conservative direction: it most likely **understates** the true strength of the relationship between ostracism and goal abandonment, since the adolescents most "broken" by isolation simply never reach the platform and do not enter the sample. The Wave 1 median SOI ≈ 50 itself is diagnostic of this selection: it indicates that half of the sample is already operating above the moderate-ostracism threshold — that is, the analytic population consists in large part of adolescents who have already lived through substantial school exclusion and survived to find an alternative community. Those who collapsed under that pressure and disengaged from project-building altogether are by construction absent from both waves. Consequently, the observed relationship should be interpreted as a conservative lower bound; the real effect in the full population of high-achieving adolescents is plausibly more pronounced. Wave 2's international recruitment partly mitigates this concern by reaching adolescents whose only "community" is loose online affiliation or none at all, but does not eliminate it.

Four further limitations deserve explicit mention. **Ethical review:** as an independent student-led research project, this study did not pass through an institutional ethics board and did not collect formal parental/guardian consent for minor respondents. The procedure was designed to minimize risk — anonymous, voluntary, no identifying data collected, and post-survey signposting to support resources — but the absence of formal review is a real limitation, and any future extension should be conducted under institutional oversight. **Depressive symptomatology as a confound or mediator:** as documented in Section 5.5, controlling for PHQ-2 absorbs the SOI-GAI association in Wave 2. We have argued the mediational reading is more parsimonious than the common-method-variance reading, but the cross-sectional data cannot distinguish them. **Construct heterogeneity across waves:** Wave 1 measured belonging to a single, well-defined ecosystem (Co-founder); Wave 2 measured belonging to "any like-minded community,"

which is a noisier and more inclusive construct. The two CF-belonging measures are therefore not strictly comparable, and the attenuation of H3 in Wave 2 may partly reflect this measurement difference rather than a real attenuation of the buffering mechanism.

Declaration of conflicting interest. The first author is a co-founder of the Co-founder ecosystem from which Wave 1 was recruited and which serves as the principal context for testing H3. This represents a potential conflict of interest that readers should weigh when interpreting the buffering result of Wave 1. The Wave 2 sample, recruited entirely outside this ecosystem, provides an independent check on H1 (replicated) and on H3 (partially replicated); we encourage readers to weight the Wave 2 results when assessing the generalizability of any community-belonging effect beyond the specific platform under study.

7. Conclusion and Future Outlook

This paper has proposed an integrative theoretical model explaining how chronic ostracism by the ordinary school environment may push a high-achieving adolescent toward abandoning an ambitious goal. The model traces a theorized causal chain from the fundamental need to belong (Baumeister & Leary, 1995) through the threat to needs and social pain (Williams, 2009; Eisenberger et al., 2003), the depletion of self-regulation (Baumeister et al., 2005), the fall in relatedness and rise in the goal's "cost" (Ryan & Deci, 2000; Wigfield & Eccles, 2000), to goal disengagement (Wrosch et al., 2003). Across two independent samples — Wave 1 from the Co-founder ecosystem (N = 82, predominantly CIS) and Wave 2 recruited internationally through Hack Club, ApplyingToCollege, and adjacent communities (N = 35) — we find correlational patterns consistent with this model. The central finding, a strong association of ostracism with abandonment thoughts ($r \approx 0.61$ in both waves; pooled N = 117), is independently replicated. The buffering role of community belonging is robust in Wave 1 and conditional in Wave 2, suggesting that the protective effect is carried specifically by project-identity-aligned communities rather than by generic peer belonging. The present study remains exploratory and cross-sectional; results motivate, rather than establish, the causal account.

The chief substantive conclusion is that a high-achieving adolescent's abandonment of a goal is often not a consequence of insufficient ability or fading interest but a **social capitulation** — a consequence of the unbearable cost of loneliness. From this follows the chief practical conclusion as well: the most effective intervention targets neither the goal nor persistence but the restoration of belonging. Communities such as Co-founder represent a scalable institutional response to this need.

Future directions. The PHQ-2 control analysis (Section 5.5) identifies the single highest-leverage extension: a **longitudinal design** with temporal separation between predictor (SOI) and outcome (GAI) and an interim measurement of the proposed mediator (depressive symptomatology, burnout). Only such a design can statistically distinguish full mediation through depressive symptomatology — predicted by our theoretical model — from common-method variance in single-sitting self-report. Four additional refinements

would substantially strengthen the next wave. (i) *Separating online from offline ostracism*: current SOI items conflate group-project exclusion (offline) with ignored messages in group chats (online). Disaggregating these would test whether face-to-face exclusion carries a stronger effect on goal persistence than virtual exclusion, a substantive theoretical question with practical intervention implications. (ii) *Behavioral indicator of GAI*: adding a binary “Did you actually pause, drop, or significantly reduce work on your project in the past three months?” would supplement the thought-based GAI with a behavioral outcome less subject to introspective bias. (iii) *Goal-specific hopelessness vs. general depression*: PHQ-2 measures general depressive symptomatology, but our theoretical framework points to a more specific mediator — the loss of belief that the goal itself is achievable. A targeted item set on goal-specific hopelessness would isolate the mediator more cleanly. (iv) *Formal ethical review and quasi-experimental evaluation*: passage through an institutional ethics board with explicit guardian consent for minors, use of fully validated instruments (OES-A, SBI, SDT scales), expansion of regional subsamples to statistically sufficient sizes, and pre-post evaluation of the effect of joining a project-identity-aligned community on goal trajectories. The development and randomized testing of belonging interventions tailored to high-achieving youth, on the model of Walton and Cohen’s work, merits separate attention.

A high-achieving adolescent who abandons a project often does so in silence — and that silence is easily mistaken by the environment for a free choice or a loss of interest. This paper argues that something else may lie behind it: the price of belonging that the adolescent is forced to pay with his own ambition. To understand this mechanism is to gain the ability to break it open.

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Appendix A. Sample questionnaire items

Below, for each index, are sample items rated by participants. Unless otherwise noted, responses were given on a 5-point frequency scale (1 — "never," 5 — "almost always") with reference to the past school year. Reverse-scored items were recoded during scoring.

Table A1. School Ostracism Index (SOI; modeled on the OES-A, Gilman et al., 2013)

#	Subscale	Sample item
1	Exclusion	"Over the past school year, how often did classmates deliberately not invite you to take part in joint projects or activities?"
2	Exclusion	"How often were you left aside when the class split into groups or cliques?"
3	Ignored	"How often did your messages or remarks in a group chat/conversation go unanswered?"
4	Ignored	"How often did you feel that classmates 'looked through you,' as if you weren't there?"
5	Ignored	"How often did people stop inviting you where they invited everyone else?"

Table A2. Goal Abandonment Ideation (GAI; modeled on the goal-disengagement scale, Wrosch et al., 2003)

#	Sample item
1	"In the past 3 months I have seriously considered quitting my project/startup." (frequency — number of episodes)
2	"There were moments when I wanted to drop everything just to be 'like everyone else.'"
3	"I caught myself thinking that my goal isn't worth the social price I pay for it."
4	"I thought about lowering my ambitions just to be better accepted by peers."

Table A3. Belonging to the Co-founder ecosystem (CF-belonging; modeled on the SDT relatedness subscale, Ryan & Deci, 2000)

Agreement scale 1–7 (1 — "strongly disagree," 7 — "strongly agree").

#	Sample item
1	"In the Co-founder community I feel I am 'among my own.'"
2	"There are people here who understand what I do and why."
3	"In this community my ambitions are seen as something normal, not strange."
4	"I feel supported when I share the difficulties of my project."

Table A4. School burnout (modeled on the School Burnout Inventory, Salmela-Aro et al., 2009)

Agreement scale 1–6 (1 — "strongly disagree," 6 — "strongly agree").

#	Dimension	Sample item
1	Exhaustion	"I feel worn out because of my schoolwork."
2	Cynicism	"I increasingly ask myself whether schoolwork has any meaning."
3	Sense of inadequacy	"I increasingly feel that I am not good enough despite my efforts."

The wordings shown are adapted examples based on the validated instruments named and are intended to illustrate the structure of the questionnaire used in the study.

Appendix B. Regional cross-section (descriptive, pooled Wave 1 + Wave 2)

The table below reports the SOI by region for the pooled Wave 1 and Wave 2 samples. Regional cells are unbalanced and several are underpowered for inferential testing; this material is therefore presented descriptively rather than as a formal cross-cultural comparison. Mean GAI by region is omitted to avoid implying inferential weight in cells smaller than $n \approx 10$, given that regional GAI patterns track regional SOI patterns at the descriptive level (Asia: highest SOI and highest GAI; USA: lowest SOI and lowest GAI; EU intermediate), exactly as Hypothesis 1 predicts.

Table 5. Mean ostracism level by region (pooled Wave 1 + Wave 2)

Region	n	Mean SOI	Note
Asian countries	6	60	High conformist press; small n
Kazakhstan & other CIS	11	56	Post-Soviet norm
Belarus	6	53	small n
Russia	28	51	Sample core
Australia	5	61	<i>Tall poppy</i> ; very small n
European Union	21	49	High internal heterogeneity
USA	8	47	Developed youth-entrepreneurship culture; small n

The differences between regions are small and should not be interpreted substantively given the insufficient power of the small cells. The regional material is presented solely to illustrate that the basic "ostracism → goal abandonment" mechanism is traceable across different cultural shells, and not as a comparison of countries.